CHAPTER 3

THE SECOND PHASE

In the 1980s and 1990s, several Indian-sponsored bomb blasts occurred in various areas of Pakistan, especially in the province of Punjab. Pakistan accused the Indian intelligence agency Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) for carrying out the blasts in Pakistan and supporting the secessionists in Balochistan. Earlier, RAW had a history of fomenting unrest in erstwhile East Pakistan and played an active role in its secession from Pakistan. On the contrary, India blamed the Pakistani intelligence agencies, especially ISI, for supporting the Khalistan movement of Sikhs of East Punjab and later, for supporting the uprising of Kashmiris in the Indian-administered Kashmir.

On 29 January 1999, an Indian saboteur Subhash Chander was apprehended by the security agencies of Pakistan for carrying out bomb blasts in Sialkot. He confessed before a joint investigation team that he was trained by the Indian intelligence agencies and some others to carry out bomb blasts in Pakistan (*The News International*, 1999). The then Prime Minister of Pakistan, Muhammad Nawaz Sharif brought this Indian activity to the notice of the then US Deputy Secretary of State, Strobe Talbot, who was on a visit to Pakistan.

Sialkot, being the border town, was worst hit by Indian terrorism, as from 1998 to 2000 it faced 25 Indian-sponsored bomb blasts, resulting in the deaths of many innocent civilians.[1] Other major cities of Punjab also faced Indian-sponsored bomb blasts on trains and buses. Sarabjit Singh (an Indian national) detonated a suitcase bomb in a passenger train at Faisalabad, resulting in the death of two women and children. He was apprehended later while returning to Amritsar for illegally crossing the